

CHANGING FROM VICTIM TO SURVIVOR

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Identify the traits of a victim versus those of a survivor.
2. Evaluate current status as either a victim or a survivor.
3. Increase confidence toward facing life with a sense of empowerment.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)
- Sexual Abuse

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The client may be far down the road toward becoming a survivor instead of a victim. On the other hand, the client may be stuck in victim status and this assignment will help him/her sort through traits that keep him/her in that status. Review his/her list of descriptors to make sure that the positive, confident, and healthy descriptors are under the label of "Survivor" while the more negative, self-defeating, depressive descriptors are under the column labeled "Victim." Reinforce motivation to move from victim to survivor and point out the many benefits that accrue as he/she changes this status of perspective.

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It is natural to view yourself as a victim and to experience all of the feelings and attitudes that accompany that victim status when the abuse has only recently occurred or there has been no opportunity for working through the emotions and thoughts connected to the abuse. It takes time and effort to move from the status of being a victim to becoming a survivor. The feelings and thoughts associated with being a victim are overwhelmingly negative and self-defeating. The feelings and thoughts associated with being a survivor, on the other hand, are more positive, forward looking, and confident. While it is natural and expected that everyone who has been exposed to abuse starts with feeling like a victim, realization of the potential of this person can only be achieved if their status changes to that of becoming a survivor. This exercise will help you understand the differences between victims and survivors and help you define your own current status.

1. The following words or phrases describe either a victim or a survivor, but they are presented to you in a jumbled and mixed-up order. Your task is to look at each word or phrase and rewrite it under the column labeled "Victim" or the column labeled "Survivor." You will have to sort through the list to finally end up with a profile of words that describe the victim and words that describe a survivor.

List of Descriptors

Depressed	Preoccupied with trauma
Has overcome pain	Enjoys living
Blames perpetrator	Lives in the past
Pessimistic	Wants understanding
Hopeless	Enjoys people
Empowered	Letting go of anger
Trauma is in perspective	Growing in trust
Defeated	No energy
Lives in the present and future	Dominated by fear
Helpless	More smiles than tears
Hopeful	Distrustful
Withdrawn socially	Bitter
Optimistic	Confident
Ashamed	Renewed energy

Needs sympathy

Victim

Focused on the pain

Survivor

2. As you look through your list of words and phrases that describe both the victim and the survivor, do you see yourself more as a victim or as a survivor? Why?

3. Which three of the descriptor words or phrases are the most accurate in describing you and your current status?

4. What three words or phrases were most accurate in describing you as a child after the trauma occurred?

5. What three words or phrases best described you a year ago before you began the journey toward becoming a survivor?

6. On a scale of 1 to 5, rate your degree of feeling like a victim (1) or a survivor (5).

1	2	3	4	5
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Victim

Survivor

7. What has helped you the most in moving from being a victim to becoming a survivor?
